
Mowing-Season Low Back

Companion Workbook — break the May lockup
pattern

NATE RATCLIFF, LMT

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HEALING HANDS BY NATE

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Continuity Member Edition — Month 5 Workbook

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Introduction

A PRINTABLE COMPANION TO THE MONTH 5 MODULE. Break the May lockup pattern.

CHAPTER 1

How to use this workbook

PRINT IT. KEEP IT ON THE WORKBENCH OR IN the mudroom — wherever you go before you head out to mow.

The 3-minute pre-mow and 6-minute post-mow protocols are the whole game. This workbook keeps you honest about doing them.

Bring it to your next session.

CHAPTER 2

Where You Are Today — Mowing Season Self-Check

MY LOW BACK AT THE START OF MOWING SEASON (rate 0-10):

Stiffness in low back
[____]
Hip flexor tightness
[____]
Pain when standing up after sitting
[____]
Pain with forward bending (touching toes)
[____]
Pain with side bending
[____]
One side worse than the other?
[R / L / Equal]

How many years have I had a “spring back lockup” episode? ____ years

Approximate number of acres / yard size I mow: _____

Mower type: [] Push / [] Self-propelled / [] Riding / [] Other: ____

Average mowing session length: ____ hours

How much physical activity did I do during the winter just past?

- [] Almost none (sedentary)
- [] Some walking, basic activity
- [] Regular but light movement
- [] Consistent exercise routine

Three honest sentences about my mowing season pattern:

1.

2.

3.

CHAPTER 3

Reflection Prompts

PROMPT 1: DESCRIBE THE WORST SPRING BACK lockup you've ever had. What happened the day of? The next morning? How long did it take to recover?

Prompt 2: Be honest about your winter movement habits. What does a typical winter week look like for you physically? What dropped off compared to summer?

Prompt 3: If you actually did the 3-minute pre-mow warm-up every time before the mower started, what would have to change in your routine? Is anything in the way besides “feels unnecessary”?

CHAPTER 4

Your Mowing-Season Protocol Commitment

WHERE I'LL KEEP THIS WORKBOOK (SO I SEE IT before mowing): _____

Where I'll do the pre-mow warm-up (outside, garage, kitchen): _____

Where I'll do the post-mow recovery (inside, on the porch, etc.): _____

My specific commitment:

- [] Pre-mow 3-minute warm-up EVERY time, no exceptions
 - [] Post-mow 6-minute recovery within 30 minutes of coming inside
 - [] One preventive bodywork session early May (before peak season)
 - [] Daily glute activation throughout April-May to wake up dormant muscles
-

CHAPTER 5

Mowing-Day Tracker

USE THIS FOR EACH MOWING DAY THROUGH THE season. Photocopy if you need more space.

Mowing Day 1 — Date: ____

Pre-mow warm-up done? [Yes / No]

Mowing duration: ____ hours / **Type:** push / riding / both

Post-mow recovery done? [Yes / No] / **How soon after stopping:** ____ min

Low back at end of day (0-10): [__]

Low back next morning (0-10): [__]

Notes: _____

Mowing Day 2 — Date: ____

Pre-mow warm-up done? [Yes / No]

Mowing duration: ____ hours / **Type:** push / riding / both

Post-mow recovery done? [Yes / No] / **How soon after stopping:** ____ min

Low back at end of day (0-10): [__]

Low back next morning (0-10): [__]

Notes: _____

Mowing Day 3 — Date: _____

Pre-mow warm-up done? [Yes / No]

Mowing duration: __ hours / **Type:** push / riding / both

Post-mow recovery done? [Yes / No] / **How soon after stopping:** __ min

Low back at end of day (0-10): [__]

Low back next morning (0-10): [__]

Notes: _____

Mowing Day 4 — Date: _____

Pre-mow warm-up done? [Yes / No]

Mowing duration: __ hours / **Type:** push / riding / both

Post-mow recovery done? [Yes / No] / **How soon after stopping:** __ min

Low back at end of day (0-10): [__]

Low back next morning (0-10): [__]

Notes: _____

CHAPTER 6

End-of-Month Reflection (do this in late May or early June)

HOW MANY MOWING DAYS THIS MONTH? ____

How many included the pre-mow warm-up? ____

How many included the post-mow recovery? ____

Worst low back day of the month (0-10): [__]

**Compared to last spring's mowing season
(worse / same / better):**

**What did I notice on days I did the protocols vs.
days I didn't?**

Commitment for rest of mowing season:

CHAPTER 7

Warning Signs Quick-Reference (cut out and keep with your tracker)

SEE YOUR DOCTOR IF ANY OF THESE SHOW UP after mowing:

- Sharp, shooting pain down one leg
- Numbness or tingling in legs or feet
- Weakness in legs (foot drop, can't push off properly)
- Pain that doesn't improve at all over 5-7 days
- Pain that gets worse instead of better
- Sudden severe pain during activity (something popped or tore)

Go to the ER immediately for:

- Bladder or bowel function changes
- Loss of sensation in the saddle area (between the legs)

Normal mowing soreness doesn't include any of the above. If you have these, don't try to stretch through it.

CHAPTER 8

Try this for 7 days

IF YOU DO NOTHING ELSE FROM THIS WORKBOOK, try this:

Glute squeezes. 10 reps. Three times a day. Every day for one week. Pre-season.

Stand, sit, walking — doesn't matter. Just squeeze your glutes hard for 5 seconds, release, repeat 10 times. Morning, midday, evening.

This wakes up the muscles that should be doing the work when you mow. Most people are stunned by how weak their glutes are after winter. A week of activation makes the May low back lockup dramatically less likely.

Bring this workbook to your next session.

— Nate



This book was crafted by Nate Ratcliff,
LMT and published by Healing Hands By
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